

Slowly but surely

SOMETIMES, the world is simply not ready. Throughout history we've seen ideas that were so outlandish that they were outlawed and those who preached them were branded heretics and banished. Those ideas had to bide their time before they could resurface. Then the academia would pick them up and have elaborate discussions, a eventually, these ideas would be worthy of public discourse. Then began the arduous process as society slowly became conditioned to accept the idea.

This process, from start to finish, would take decades in the past. However, now, the time taken for an outlandish idea to become mainstream has significantly reduced. This time period within which an idea appears normal and acceptable is called the Overton Window, after Joseph P. Overton who proposed the theory. If an idea lies outside the confines of the Overton Window, you can bring it in simply by conditioning the people. A simple approach is to propose an even more outlandish idea, thereby softening the blow an making the former idea seem not so outlandish as previously thought. People do it all the time, and politicians lead the pack.

When it comes to AI, I believe we're experiencing just that. So many great minds of our time have been very vocal about the runaway effect of AI. Commonly known as the singularity, the runaway effect is when an AI rapidly evolves to the extent that it can easily gain control over anything that's digital. In almost every piece of science fiction, it then proceeds to wipe out humanity. AI experts will vouch for the fact that the singularity is far from coming into existence, however, technology giants aren't blind to the immense profit that stands to be gained from AI technologies. Everything under the sun will have some element of AI in the future but only if people accept it.

If we were to publicly chart the natural progression of AI, then people will soon realise that their jobs are as good as gone once an AI is put in place. So naturally, they are going to be wary of AI technologies i.e. it remains outside the Overton Window. Now, if technology giants were to paint a very drastic picture of futuristic AI, then people are going to be

more accepting of whatever feeble AI we have right now.

Pull your smartphone out and try talking to the intelligent assistant. Be as casual as you can be. You'll soon realise that the AI behind smartphone assistants are utterly dumb. They are nowhere close to the Tony Stark's Jarvis but they're marketed so. This conditions humans to believe that the true singularity is farther than it really is. Ergo, humans are more than willing to tolerate current forms of AI and you don't need us to tell you that most of these smart assistants are always listening and always recording. Passing on your private conversations, daily musings, browsing and shopping habits to massive computers who are using all of that data to get smarter, and therefore, closer to the singularity.

Most of us who follow research on AI know how rapidly the technology is progressing. We're already on our way towards building the brain-like neural net and the human brain has already been simulated successfully. AI has progressed to the extent that it can now train itself without the need for massive amounts of data. Case in point, DeepMind's AlphaGo Zero which learnt entirely on its own by playing the game with itself over and over again, in a fraction of the time it took its predecessor to learn the game. However, these things are no longer viewed by humanity as a threat even though it very much is for a lot of jobs. Each moment you spend on a connected device is sending data to some server which is then used to make some AI more accurate. In order for the people to more amiable towards the whole idea of AI, technology companies have to introduce AI in a staggered manner. All while putting out a facade of hope. Every company dabbling in AI will tell you that AI will create more jobs, especially in the AI training domain. What they fail to mention is that, AI is not going to create more of the jobs it replaces. And it's only a matter of time before it replaces the very same jobs that it helped create in the first place. But you're not going to realise any of that in time, the technology giants of today have seen to that.

I'd wish you a happy new year, if I thought there was anything to be happy about... 



"If we were to publicly chart the natural progression of AI, then people will soon realise that their jobs are as good as gone once an AI is put in place."



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
[@mithun_mohandas](https://twitter.com/mithun_mohandas) |
mithun@digit.in